

It needed to be disposed of safely and in a controlled manner. The Russian Aviation and Space Agency announced that the re-entry of the station will take place in March of that year.

A fuelled Progress vehicle was launched in January and docked onto the space station. The engines of the Progress vehicle were fired several times at regular intervals to “brake” and slow down Mir, lowering it into the Earth’s atmosphere.

Most of Mir burnt up in the atmosphere, as normally occurs with re-entering space objects that have to be disposed of. However, some pieces did impact on the ocean surface, creating an effect similar to the crash landing of one or two small aircraft.

International Space Station

With the Cold War long over and relations between the USA, European nations and Russia better than ever before, it made a lot of sense for all the parties to get together in the formation of the next space station. Each of them already had their own plans, but the combined efforts not only proved to be more economical, but also much faster.

The International Space Station is a venture of international cooperation among NASA, the Russian Federal Space Agency (RFSA), Canadian Space Agency (CSA), Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA), and 11 members of the European Space Agency (ESA): Belgium, Denmark, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland and the United Kingdom.

Now the largest spacecraft ever built, the orbital assembly of the space station began with the launch from Kazakhstan of its first bus-sized component, the Russian-built Zarya, on November 20, 1998. The launch began an international construction project of unprecedented complexity and sophistication.

A few weeks later, Space Shuttle Endeavour carried aloft the Unity connector module in December 1998. Constructed on opposite sides of Earth, Unity and Zarya met for the first time in space and were joined to begin the orbital station’s assembly. Over the years, many more modules and other parts were added, making the ISS the behemoth it is today. Some of the more important ones are:

Zarya

The first module of the entire ISS, Zarya – Russian for “sunrise” – provided orientation control, communications and electrical power attached to the passive Unity, till later advanced modules made these tasks obsolete. It is 12.6 meters (41.2 feet) long and 4.1 meters (13.5 feet wide) at its widest point. It has an operational